



BEFORE

Ireland, a mainly Catholic country, had a fraught relationship with its Protestant neighbor, Britain, for many centuries.

THE BRITISH IN IRELAND

After victory in the English Civil War, **Oliver Cromwell** <<264–65 invaded and conquered the whole of Ireland, opening it up to colonization by English and Scottish Protestants. In 1782 Ireland received an independent parliament, but after revolts in 1798 this was abolished. Britain and Ireland were united in 1801.

THE EASTER RISING

Anger erupted in April 1916 in a rebellion known as the Easter Rising. Militant Irish Republicans seized several key locations in Dublin and issued the **Proclamation of the Republic**, declaring Ireland to be an independent state. After six days of fighting, the British suppressed the uprising and executed its leaders, which generated sympathy for the Republican cause and awakened nationalist sentiment.



MICHAEL COLLINS

IRISH FREE STATE

In 1921 Michael Collins, a Republican leader, was sent to London to negotiate a treaty with the British. Ireland was to be self-governing but kept within the British Empire. Six counties in the region of Ulster (Northern Ireland) remained part of the UK. In 1922 Collins founded the **Irish Free State** (later, the Irish Republic). A year of civil war followed, as many Republicans rejected partition.

THE NORTH

In the largely Protestant north, nationalists, in favor of a united Ireland, were seen as a threat. This led to preferential treatment of Protestant Unionists in jobs and housing. Despite brief campaigns by the paramilitary **Irish Republican Army** (IRA), formed in the 1920s, the province was stable. However, in 1966 Unionists formed the Ulster Volunteer Force (UVF) in response to the Republican threat and the violence escalated.

In September 1968, the Northern Ireland Civil Rights Association (NICRA), a predominantly Catholic organization, announced a march was to take place in the city of Derry on October 5, 1968 to demand an end to discrimination against Irish Catholics. A Protestant organization, the Apprentice Boys of Derry, announced they would also march at that time. NICRA was barred from marching by the British Government but decided to proceed. The Royal Ulster Constabulary (RUC), armed with truncheons, charged at the marchers. Images of the violence shocked many around the world. Northern Irish Students formed a more radical civil rights group called the People's Democracy (PD) based on socialist principles (see pp.336–37). Inspired by Martin Luther King Jr. (see pp.432–33), about 40 members of the PD marched from the city of Belfast to Derry on January 1, 1969 to highlight social injustices in Northern Ireland. The march was attacked by Unionists

SECTARIANISM Division of a society into religious factions, such as Protestant and Catholic, in which strong identification with the values within each faction leads to exclusion of those with different values.

along its route with iron bars and stones. These events precipitated a split in the IRA (see BEFORE): the Official IRA, and the Provisional IRA. The Provisional IRA was determined to use force to reunite Ireland, and launched an armed attack against British rule.

Peaceful protest

The Provisional IRA became closely involved in civilian demonstrations and riots against the British. The Unionist UVF began to use violence to “protect the Protestant community” from the Provisional IRA and launched offensives against Catholics and the Irish Republic (see BEFORE). The British Government responded by implementing Operation “Demetrius” in Northern Ireland on August 9, 1971. This introduced

Confrontation

Civil rights protesters vent their frustrations at British soldiers dressed in riot gear, across a barricade in Derry on Bloody Sunday. The soldiers were armed with guns containing rubber bullets. Tensions came to a head when stones were thrown at the soldiers. Rubber bullets were replaced with live ammunition, leaving 13 dead.

The Troubles

For about 30 years, from the 1960s to the 1990s, repeated acts of intense violence flared between Northern Ireland's mostly Catholic, nationalist community, who wanted to break from British rule, and the principally Protestant Unionist, pro-British, community—a period known as “the Troubles.”

“This Sunday became known as **Bloody Sunday** and bloody it was... the army ran amok that day and shot without thinking... It was sheer unadulterated murder. **It was murder.**”

MAJOR HUBERT O'NEILL, CORONER,
AUGUST 21, 1973

